

The Storm at Home

How *The Odyssey*, *Circe*, and David Ligare's *Penelope* Portray the Strength of Women in Ancient Greek Mythology

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David Ligare's *Penelope*

This project represents my own original work. No outside help has been provided for this project. I understand that if my entry is selected as a winner, my entry and my name will be published on the CANE website.

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In Madeline Miller's *Circe*, Circe's experiences parallel Penelope's in Homer's *The Odyssey*. These two women must fight against stereotypical images of weak, dependent women. Circe is exiled to the island of Aiaia for using harmful magic. Penelope awaits her husband for 20 years, protecting herself from her suitors. David Ligare's painting of Penelope highlights the many commonalities between Penelope and Circe. His depiction of Penelope facing away from the sea illustrates Circe and Penelope's confinement to their homes, unable to seek adventure. Furthermore, his portrayal of Penelope's stoic face highlights the many struggles Circe and Penelope endure, worn out by many years of heartbreak and subjugation.

Penelope looks away from the sea in Ligare's painting, only able to see the island of Ithaca. The sea is symbolic of adventure, as it is where heroes embark on their journeys. Penelope facing away from the sea thus illustrates her inability to seek adventure as she, along with Circe, is constrained to her home; Penelope is confined to her house in Ithaca, and Circe is exiled to a hut in Aiaia. They are restricted to the small worlds in which they are allowed to live: "My days had narrowed to the ambit of my eyes and my fingers' ends" (Miller 200-201). The word "narrowed" encapsulates this confinement as both Circe and Penelope are only allowed to wander in their designated islands. Thus, the only glimpses of adventure these women get are from stories. Circe listens to the stories of the outside world from her visitors; she learns of the struggles of common men from Glaucos, the epic battles of heroes from Odysseus, and divine gossip from Hermes: "He showed me his scars, and in return he let me pretend that I had none" (237). Odysseus tells Circe of the perils he faced in his journey, receiving many scars. However, though Circe is forbidden from leaving Aiaia, she has received scars like Odysseus—emotional scars. Circe raises Aeëtes by herself as his parents neglect him. But Aeëtes leaves Circe, betraying her and dismissing her importance: "He said as if it were no more than a point of minor

interest. I felt like I was turning to stone” (34). The phrase “a point of minor interest” describes the minimal extent to which Aeëtes cares for Circe, and the illustration of her turning to stone connects to Ligare’s emotionless Penelope. In Ligare’s painting, Penelope is emotionless as a stone, for she has been weathered by years of hardship. Having felt betrayed, neglected, and abused, Circe can no longer bear the pain of heartbreak and misery, turning into a stone that now allows no emotion.

Just as Odysseus loses his crew, Penelope and Circe face loss: Penelope loses her husband for 20 years and Circe loses her family when she is exiled into Aiaia: “All those years I had spent with them were like a stone tossed in a pool. Already, the ripples were gone” (78). Stone imagery is used again as the memories Circe had of her family are encapsulated in a stone, but this stone is lost in a pool of eternal isolation with no traces left, for no one loves hers and longs to see her. The heartbreak from loss and betrayal and the subjugation by men (i.e. stranded travelers abusing Circe and suitors seeking Penelope) wear down both women.

Circe and Penelope faced many adversities. Relegated to the role of housekeeping, they could not look towards the seas of adventure as their lives were meant to be within the domains of the household. However, they still received many scars that wore them down. They had to find power in a world that gave them none: ““Sorcery cannot be taught. You find it yourself, or you do not”” (69). For Circe, sorcery was her power; through many failures and tragedies, she was able to master *pharmaka* and find strength. For Penelope, her guile and skill in weaving enabled her to fend off her suitors until Odysseus returned. Thus, Ligare’s painting of Penelope encapsulates Circe and Penelope in that though they could not face the sea for adventure, and though they were worn down by their years of hardship and isolation, they found power within themselves to challenge stereotypes and oppression, making them worthy to be admired, making

them worthy to be painted not as victims who were defeated by years of containment, but as independent women who prevailed against the adversities set against them.

Bibliography:

Miller, Madeline. *Circe*. Hachette Book Group USA, 2019.

Homer, et al. *The Odyssey*. Penguin, 2001.

Ligare, David. *Penelope*. 1980. Oil on canvas. Crocker Art Museum, Sacramento.